

Is AI generally worse for the environment than everything else we do?

Posted by u/kerriparsons • 0 points • 5 comments

DISCLAIMER- I am definitely not saying we shouldn't be aware or work on the impact ai has on the environment. I am also not educated in this field and that's why I am asking!!!

I keep seeing an ongoing trend of people stating that "ai destroys the environment" and "wow how could you use chat gpt." I have my own issues with AI such as art, film, media, etc... but I am really curious why people are making this claim when literally everything else we do harms the environment, some a hundred times more than chat gpt.

My examples to argue this/ask what others think are:

- bitcoin mining consumes more electricity annually than Argentina
- the average gas car emits 4.6 metric tons of CO2 per year
- the streaming industry such as Netflix uses A ton of energy annually but nobody talks about that

I feel like the focus should be on how to curb the harm instead of banning it altogether? I don't know what do you think?

Comments

u/Beneficial-Bus-6630 • 1 points • 2025-07-17 17:21 UTC

Yes

u/Kman17 • 1 points • 2025-06-26 17:31 UTC

I mean it's true that computing power both (1) requires electric power generation and (2) calls for more CPU's to be manufactured.

Both of those are solvable problems - electric power generation is and can be moved to green (wind / solar / tidal / nuclear) and is happening.

Point 2 can be mitigated by better recycling+ of old materials. We have this problem in basically every form of material construction.

AI has kind of tiers of computational use, and that does tend to get pushed down to the user.

AI - like large data analytics - can help at identifying inefficiencies in other industries and processes, which can in turn use less resources with positive environmental impact.

While I don't know the compute footprint of ai odd the top of my head compared to other tech, I don't give it the "wasteful" label that I do bitcoin.

Bitcoin's "proof of compute" model is an inefficiency by design that has technical alternatives that mostly solve the same problem.

u/cfwang1337 • 1 points • 2025-06-25 00:32 UTC

Not "than everything else we do," for sure – that's a gigantic hyperbole.

[According to the EPA,](<https://www.epa.gov/ghgemissions/sources-greenhouse-gas-emissions>) the top sources of greenhouse gas emissions in the USA are:

1. Transportation (28%)
2. Electric power (25%)
3. Industry (23%)
4. Residential & commercial (13%)
5. Agriculture (10%)

Presumably, AI use would be split between "Industry" and "Residential & commercial."

No wonder electric cars and renewables are such a big deal!

u/melodyze • 1 points • 2025-06-24 23:41 UTC

AI isn't quite as bad as bitcoin because bitcoin mining is a straight up competition around cost to run computation, where energy costs are the main input.

So bitcoin mining all happens where the cheapest electricity is, and the cheapest electricity is coal in countries with a lot of coal and as few environmental regulations as possible. Grid reliability isn't that important because blocks are discreet, infrastructure reliability isn't that important, there's basically zero brand risk because mining pools have no brand. All that matters is cost per kwh of electricity.

AI uses a lot of computation, but there is a lot more to the infrastructure than just computation, and it's centralized around us tech companies, using disproportionately flagship US data centers for the convenience/control/quality assurance.

Those ai companies generally use other big tech companies' datacenters (Microsoft for openai, amazon for anthropic, Google for google), because they need the reliability, scale, and guarantees of the infrastructure they provide. Those big tech companies have more to think about than just cost/kwh to provide those guarantees and such with their datacenters, so they aren't necessarily located in the places with the cheapest (and thus least clean) electricity. They need an extremely reliable grid, high skilled workers, etc. So those data centers tend to be in more developed areas with more modern (and thus cleaner) power plants.

They also have brand risk and employee morale to consider, so they are further pressured to be green. Google, for example, was carbon neutral for a long time.

u/adv0catus • 2 points • 2025-06-24 21:58 UTC

AI requires an EXTREME amount of energy to run. The emissions from producing that energy are very destructive to the environment.

u/dzzi • 1 points • 2025-06-25 02:10 UTC

Can you provide more detail? I'd imagine OP has already heard someone say that but is looking for an explanation of what exactly that looks like

u/NewPurpleRider • 1 points • 2025-06-25 00:40 UTC

Until AI is able to figure out how we better use this energy more efficiently.